

Cover story **MUMBAI 26/11**

When splitting up into small teams to pursue the two terrorists on foot would have been an easier option, sitting in the vehicle made the policemen easy targets and restricted their firing options. The jeep with the three senior police officers packed in the front seat was ambushed by the two terrorists. A hail of bullets killed the leadership of the Maharashtra ATS, which severely demoralised an already shaken police force and resigned it to waiting for anti-terrorist forces.

5

12 midnight

Mumbai Police Failed to Engage the Terrorists at the Taj Hotel

Apart from lack of arms, there were not enough policemen to keep the pressure up on terrorists

For three crucial hours after the attack, all the four terrorists were holed up in the upper floors of the Taj after killing over 20 persons in the lobby. The policemen who engaged them for the first few hours were too few in number to prove effective to maintain 'contact' with the terrorists. Contact is the military term which refers to the act of keeping the enemy pinned down in a firefight; it puts the enemy on the defensive and prevents them from moving or achieving their objectives. What the police lacked in firepower, they could have made up in sheer numbers but sufficient policemen were not deployed in the hotel. Contact was broken and the terrorists left to have a free run of the hotel as the police waited first for the Marcos and later the NSG to arrive. It was at least three hours before the Marine Commandos arrived and resumed the engagement with the terrorists at around 2.30 a.m. By then, the four terrorists had valuable time to study the layout of the hotel; they were also being constantly briefed by their handlers in Pakistan.

6

09.00 a.m.

The NSG Arrived Late

The bureaucratic hurdles that led to further delay of the NSG proved advantageous for the terrorists

The NSG was alerted within two hours of the attacks but it took them nearly seven hours to reach the besieged city. They were summoned by Home Secretary Madhukar Gupta who called NSG chief J.K. Dutt at around 11.30 p.m. The commandos were first transported by road from their base in Manesar, Haryana, nearly 28 km from Delhi airport because they did not have dedicated airlift like helicopters



AP PHOTO/GURINDER OSAN

with night-flying capability. At least an hour was spent at the airport loading the aircraft and waiting for home minister Shivraj Patil who then accompanied the Black Cats on their flight to Mumbai. When the NSG eventually arrived at Sahar airport at 5 a.m., they were bundled into BEST buses and taken to the Mantralaya for a briefing. It was nine in the morning by the time they reached the two hotels. The second batch of commandos arrived, but was not briefed. All attention was focused on the Taj and Oberoi hotels; nobody was aware of the hostage situation at Nariman House where Abu Akasha and Abu Umar were holding Rabbi Gavriel Holtzberg and his wife hostage, along with four others.

7

09.00 a.m.

No Detailed Layouts or Maps of the Buildings Under Attack

Relying on hotel staff and locals delayed the rescue of hostages and prolonged operations

One of the precepts of a successful building intervention operation conducted by anti-terror forces is a detailed knowledge of the layouts of the buildings to be assaulted. This is why special forces often stock building plans of all vulnerable areas and buildings, and sometimes even practice mock hostage rescue drills in them. In Mumbai, the terrorists had the advantage of a detailed hostile reconnaissance conducted, as it is now suspected, by David Headley and Tahawwur Rana.

Later, the 10 terrorists who had arrived at the three spots at least 12 hours before the NSG, evidently had plenty of time to study the layouts of the buildings and site their defences. These were crucial lapses which played a deci-

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